

GILGAMESH'S REPLY TO ISHTAR

Epic of Gilgamesh, Tablet VI — the king of Uruk refuses the goddess's hand. Twelve incisions.

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No, I will not take you for a wife.

𒊕𒂵 · 𒀪𒃵𒃶𒂵𒀭𒀭 · 𒀭𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒊕𒀭 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵𒃶 ✦

xa kurt-a-mu na ta ti xu milar

The whole refusal lives in xa; one's own will is stated in the direct evidential (-mu).

You are but a short-lived blaze,

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒃶𒀭𒂵 · 𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵 ✦

sat-a-ka ti kirut i plist

"A flame of an instant" — kirut names both the flame and the ash.

A rickety door that keeps out

Neither wind nor rain.

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒀭𒀪𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒊕𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 ·

𒍪𒃶𒃶𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵 · 𒀭𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵 ✦

sat-a-ka ta inkil k'akar ki xa klatak-a-ka ta surar sa lustut u sa pals

You are a palace whose roof

Threatens to fall upon its guests;

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒃶𒃶𒀪 · 𒀭𒃶𒀭𒂵𒂵𒀭 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒀭𒀭𒂵 · 𒀭𒀭𒂵𒀪𒂵𒂵𒂵 ·

𒍪𒃶𒀭𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭𒂵 · 𒊕𒀭𒂵 · 𒍪𒀭𒂵𒂵𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭 ✦

sat-a-ka ti purk prulim ki nu hulk-a-ka sirmal i ku xu spilamar i ku

A threat is an inferred future: nu forces -ka.

You are the headband that smothers

The one who wears it;

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒃶𒃶𒂵 ✦

𒂵𒃶𒂵𒀭𒀭𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒃶𒃶𒀪𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵𒃶𒀭𒂵𒂵𒀭𒃶𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭 ✦

sat-a-ka ti hast i kart ; arilus-a-ka nark ki stirmalp-a-ka ta ku

Drikx has no causative: "you are the head-cloth; short of air is the man who dons it".

You are the pitch that defiles

Whoever touches it;

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒀭𒀭𒂵 · 𒀭𒀭𒃶𒀪𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒂵𒀭𒂵𒀪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒃶𒃶𒀪

· 𒀪𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭 ✦

sat-a-ka ti sump murk ki trulk-a-ka ta nark ki plik-a-ka ta ku

You are the waterskin that spills

Over the one who carries it;

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵𒂵𒀪𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒊕𒀭𒂵𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵𒂵𒀪 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭 · 𒊕𒀭

· 𒀪𒃶𒃶𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭 ✦

sat-a-ka ti stakil ki xuln-a-ka stak i ku xu krukar i ku

No middle voice, no passive: it is the water that flows (xuln, a spontaneous process).

You are the limestone

That fouls the rampart;

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒂵𒀭𒂵𒀪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒊕𒂵𒀭𒃶𒂵𒀭 ✦

sat-a-ka ti kal ki trulk-asi-ka ta xilpan

Repetitive aspect: the fouling happens deposit after deposit. The -asi epenthesis is written as it is spoken.

You are the battering ram

That pounds the city walls;

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒃶𒂵𒀪𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒀪𒃶𒂵𒀪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒊕𒂵𒀭𒃶𒂵𒀭 · 𒃶𒀭

✦

sat-a-ka ti krakil ki krak-si-ka ta xilpan ru

The pounding lives entirely in the -si; striking in repetition.

You are the shoe too narrow

That bruises the foot.

𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒃶𒂵𒂵𒂵𒀭𒂵 · 𒀪𒃶𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒂵𒃶𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒃶𒂵𒀭

✦

sat-a-ka ti praltux krap ki tram-a-ka ta rin

Is there a single one of your lovers

Whom you ever truly loved?

𒀭𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒃶𒃶𒃶𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒃶𒃶𒃶𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 ·

𒍪𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒃶𒂵𒂵 · 𒃶𒂵𒀪𒂵

ha sat-a nat tirpar i ti ki pa tirp-a ti sa hart rikt

A question takes no ✦ closure — the final blank is where the answer belongs. "Truly": sa hart rikt, "from a true heart".

Is there one man anywhere

Whom you ever satisfied?

𒀭𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒃶𒀪𒂵 · 𒀪𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒂵 · 𒀭𒂵𒀭𒂵𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 · 𒂵𒂵 ·

𒂵𒀭𒃶𒃶𒀭𒂵𒂵 · 𒍪𒂵 · 𒀪𒀭

ha sat-a nat nark ki pa pins-a ti ta lurpin sa ku

Agentive recast: "a man from whom you received pleasure" — the source is marked (sa ku).

The text. Gilgamesh's reply to the goddess Ishtar, who offered him marriage (Epic of Gilgamesh, Tablet VI). The king refuses, listing metaphor after metaphor the goddess's inconstancy toward her lovers — a text pressed into clay more than three thousand years ago, re-incised here in the stone of taktil.

Evidentiality. The whole invective is Gilgamesh's judgment: every assertion carries the inferential -ka, except the first line, where the speaker states his own will (-mu, direct). The two closing questions lose their evidential slot and remain unclosed.

Script. Taktil: consonants in Old Italic (the framework), vowels in runes (the binding), · word separator, ✦ assertion closure. Every lexical word ends heavy, on a monometal glyph; every grammatical word ends light, on a rune. The page's single ejective, the trident-privative of 𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 (k'akar "rickety"), is seen exactly as it is heard. Display: Old Italic needs a historic font (Segoe UI Historic, Noto Sans Old Italic).

Lexicon. New root: trulk "to defile, to foul". Cluster extensions: kal > limestone, sump murk ≈ pitch/bitumen, hast i kart ≈ headband, inkil > door, stakil > waterskin, krakil > battering ram.

𒀭𒃶𒂵𒂵𒂵𒂵 ✦